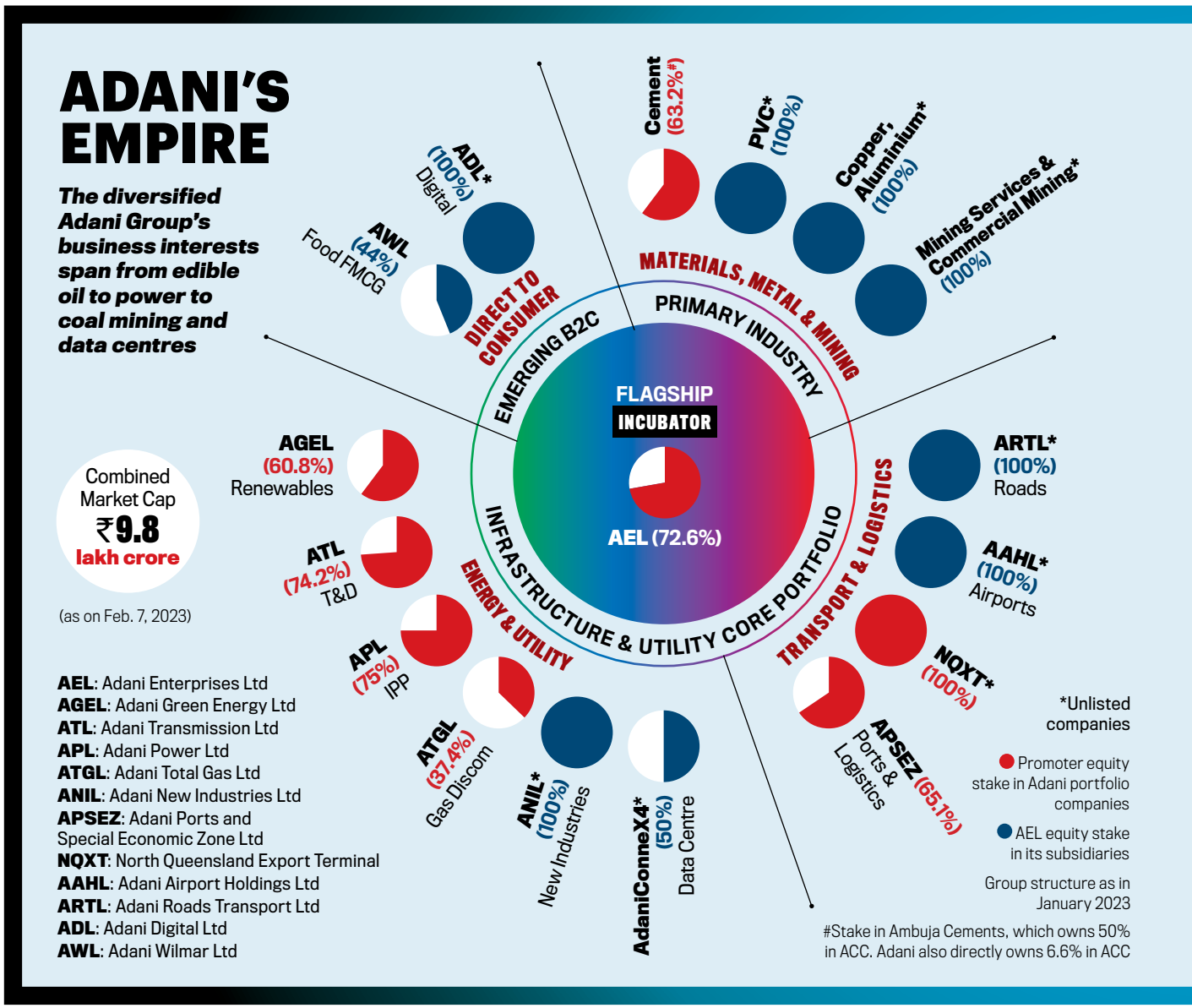
his group and also dragged him to the centre of a massive political controversy that has put the Modi government on the mat ahead of the 2024 general election. The Opposition, spearheaded by Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, charged the prime minister with favouring the businessman and called for a joint parliamentary committee (JPC) to investigate the matter (see accompanying story *The Political Blowback*). Concerns were also raised on the exposure of the largest public sector bank, the State Bank of India (SBI), and the largest state-owned insurer, the Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC), to the group, with the Opposition alleging that public money had been squandered.

On his part, the prime minister unleashed the full might of his oratorical skills in Parliament, as he lashed out at what he termed as the "ecosystem" of corruption and inefficiency that made 2004-2014 (the years of Congress-led UPA rule) a lost decade. He contrasted it with the development initiatives marking his tenure. He made no mention of Adani or any promise of a probe. Yet, it is apparent that the Adani imbroglio will not be resolved anytime soon. Apart from impairing Adani and his group, it has triggered concerns about its impact on India's financial stability and the political damage it could likely inflict on the prime minister and the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP).

HOW BAD IS THE DAMAGE TO ADANI?

In its voluminous report, Hindenburg Research accused the Adani Group of running a "brazen stock manipulation and accounting fraud scheme over the course of decades". The US firm, which has a history of "shorting" large corporate houses, raised 88 questions. Prime among the charges was that the group was using shell companies overseas, many managed by Gautam's elder brother Vinod Adani, to siphon off money from its seven listed companies and routed back



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